

LX-005

How to Convert an Internship into a PPO

Audience: Students | Stage: After It Ends | Read Time: 5 min

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01

What firms look for in interns

A PPO (Pre-Placement Offer) isn't given to the intern who knows the most law. It's given to the intern the firm can see working there full-time. The evaluation is as much about cultural fit and work ethic as it is about legal knowledge.

Firms assess three things: reliability (did you meet every deadline without being chased?), quality of work (did your research and drafting improve over the internship?), and attitude (were you pleasant to work with, open to feedback, and genuinely interested in the firm's work?).

Most firms make PPO decisions in the last week of your internship, but the evaluation starts from day one. Every interaction — how you handle criticism, whether you volunteer for tasks, how you treat support staff — is being observed. The associates you work with will be asked for their opinion. Make sure it's a good one.

02

The visibility strategy

Doing good work isn't enough if nobody notices. You need strategic visibility — not showing off, but making sure the right people see your contributions.

Volunteer for tasks from multiple partners and associates, not just your assigned supervisor. This expands the number of people who can vouch for you. When you deliver work, include a brief summary of your approach and findings — don't just send a document with no context.

Attend any team meetings, knowledge-sharing sessions, or social events you're invited to. These informal settings are where partners form opinions about whether you'd fit into the team long-term.

If the firm has a specific practice area you're passionate about, mention it early. Say: "I'm particularly interested in the M&A practice. If there's any ongoing matter where I could assist, I'd love to contribute." This shows initiative and helps the firm place you mentally in a role.

03

Asking for feedback

Don't wait until the last day to find out how you're doing. Proactively seeking feedback demonstrates maturity and a growth mindset — both qualities firms value in potential hires.

At the midpoint of your internship (typically after 2-3 weeks), ask your supervising associate for a brief chat. Frame it positively: “I’m really enjoying the experience so far. I’d love to know if there are areas where I can improve in the second half of my internship.”

Listen without getting defensive. If they say your research memos need more structure, don’t explain why you wrote it that way — say “Thank you, I’ll work on that” and actually implement the feedback in your next assignment. Visible improvement after feedback is one of the strongest signals a firm can see.

Don’t ask for feedback too frequently (once at the midpoint is usually right) and never ask a partner directly unless they’re your primary supervisor. Go through your assigned associate first.

04

The follow-up timeline

If the firm doesn’t mention a PPO during your internship, don’t panic. Many firms take 2-4 weeks after the internship ends to make decisions, especially larger firms with multiple interns.

Here’s the recommended timeline: On your last day, express your interest verbally. Something like: “I’ve really valued this experience and would love to explore the possibility of joining the team after graduation.” Keep it brief and professional.

One week after the internship ends, send a thank-you email (use the template attached to this guide). This email should express gratitude, mention a specific project or learning experience, and subtly reaffirm your interest.

If you haven’t heard anything after 3-4 weeks, send one follow-up email to your supervising associate asking if there’s been any update regarding potential positions. After that, the ball is in their court. Don’t send multiple follow-ups — it looks desperate and can actually hurt your chances.

05

Writing the PPO request

If you feel a strong connection with the firm but the internship ended without a PPO discussion, you can write a formal PPO request. This should be a concise, professional email to the managing partner or HR head.

Structure it as follows: Express gratitude for the internship opportunity. Mention 2-3 specific contributions you made (a research memo that was well-received, a matter you assisted on, a skill you developed). State your interest in joining the firm full-time and mention your availability (graduation date, bar enrollment timeline).

Keep it under 200 words. Don't oversell yourself or make it emotional. The tone should be confident but not presumptuous — you're expressing interest, not demanding a position.

Not every PPO request will succeed, and that's okay. Even if the firm doesn't have a position available, a well-written request leaves a positive impression. They might reach out when a position opens up, or refer you to another firm. The legal community remembers professionalism.

— End of Guide —